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Boulevard raises \$80M to power self-care boom driven by Botox and GLP-1 surge

The beauty industry has seen an explosion of offerings recently. Customers can now access treatments far beyond basic hair and nail care, from wrinkle-smoothing Botox and fillers to permanent laser hair removal to weight management through GLP-1 medications.

Riding this wave of industry growth is Boulevard, a provider of scheduling and payment software for the self-care sector.

The 9-year-old Boulevard just raised \$80 million in Series D funding, valuing the business at nearly \$800 million, a meaningful uptick from the \$595 million valuation it garnered three years ago. The round was led by growth equity firm JMI Equity and included participation from existing investors Index Ventures and VMG Partners.

When Boulevard launched in 2016, the company's co-founders, Matt Danna and Sean Stavropoulos, wanted to solve what seemed like a simple problem: allowing people to book hairstyling visits online.

The duo couldn't understand why salons still made clients call to make appointments. What they discovered was that salons were intentionally resistant to online scheduling: They were trying to optimize stylists' time.

So, Boulevard built a machine learning-based booking system that considers various constraints,

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such as clients' unique service needs and punctuality history.

The company initially sold their precision-scheduling software to hair salons, expanding to barbershops, spas, and nail salons.

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Boulevard's revenue soared over 500% in the last three years, partly driven by a burgeoning new client segment: medspas. These businesses, which are a hybrid between traditional day spas and medical clinics, provide nonsurgical, minimally invasive procedures ranging from microneedling and Botox to prescribing GLP-1 medications like Ozempic for weight loss.

Danna, who serves as Boulevard's CEO, said he was first surprised that medspa owners were interested in using the company's software instead of electronic medical records systems (EMRs). He discovered that EMRs are better suited for clients billing insurance, whereas medspas predominantly run on a cash-pay model.

Adapting Boulevard’s software to serve medspas was pretty straightforward, Danna said. The company became HIPAA compliant and integrated medspa-specific features, including visual charts for precise Botox and filler injection mapping.

Three years after introducing these features, Boulevard estimates that it is powering approximately 15% of all medspas in the U.S.

“I am really impressed by how beauty and medical services lines are blurring,” Danna said. “We have hair salons that offer medspa services.”

Over the years, Boulevard expanded its offerings to include an online payment system, a business offering that the company unexpectedly stumbled upon. “We ended up learning that if you make it easy to book online, it is easy to not show up for an appointment,” Danna said. “So, we started capturing credit cards to hold appointments, and that solved the problem of no-shows.”

Though Boulevard initially had no intention of charging those credit cards, customers requested the company use the data for transactions. Boulevard now estimates it will process approximately \$5 billion in payments this year.

Of course, Boulevard has plenty of competition, including [Zenoti](#), which was last valued at \$1 billion in 2020, [Fresha](#), [Booksy](#), and many others.

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LA-based Boulevard raises \$27 million for its spa management software

Jonathan Shieber — 8:01 AM PST · November 23, 2020

IMAGE CREDITS: [RUNPHOTO](#) / GETTY IMAGES

[Boulevard](#), a spa management and payment platform, has raised \$27 million in a new round of funding despite a business slowdown caused by the COVID-19 pandemic.

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Founded four years ago by Matt Danna and Sean Stavropoulos, Boulevard was inspired by Stavropoulos' inability to book a haircut and Danna's hunch that the inability of salons and spas to cater to customers like the busy programmer could be indicative of a bigger problem.

The two spent months pounding the pavement in Los Angeles pretending to be college students doing research on the industry. They spoke with salon owners in Beverly Hills, Hollywood and other trendy neighborhoods trying to get a sense of where software and services were falling short.

Through those months of interviews the two developed the booking management and payment

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That could be because of the size of the industry. There is more than \$250 billion spent per year across roughly 3 million businesses in the salon and spa category, according to data provided by the company. By comparison, fitness attracts roughly \$34 billion in annual spending from 150,000 businesses.

“With limited access to the professionals that help us look and feel our best, I think the world has realized something that our team has always recognized: Salons and spas are more than a luxury, they are essential to our well-being,” said Danna, in a statement. “We are humbled that so many businesses are placing their trust in us during such a turbulent time. This new capital will help accelerate our mission and deliver value to salons and spas that they never imagined was possible from technology.”

According to data provided by the company, Boulevard is definitely giving businesses a boost. On average, businesses increase bookings by 16%, retail revenue jumps by 18% and gratuity paid out to stylists jumps by 24% for businesses that use Boulevard, the company said. It also reduces no-shows and cancellations, and halves time spent on the phone.

“Boulevard is revitalizing the salon and spa industry, as evidenced by the company’s sustained 300-400% revenue growth over the last three years,” said Damir Becirovic of Index Ventures, whose firm

led the company's Series A round and has doubled down with the new capital infusion.

Customers using the company's software include: Chris McMillan the Salon, Heyday, MèCHE Salon, Paintbox, Sassoon Salon, SEV Laser, Spoke & Weal and TONI&GUY.

[Los Angeles-based Boulevard has raised \\$11 million for its software to manage salons and spas](#)

Boulevard now has 90 employees and will look to increase that number as it continues to expand across the country.

Investors have taken a run at the spa market in the past, with company's like MindBody valued at over \$1 billion for its software services. Indeed, that company [was taken private two years ago](#) in a \$1.9 billion transaction by Vista Equity Partners.

As Boulevard expands, the company may look to get deeper into financial services for the salons and spas that it's already working with. Given the company's window into these businesses' financing, it's not impossible to imagine a new line of business providing small business loans to these companies.

It's something that the founders would likely not rule out. And it's a way to provide more tools to entrepreneurs that often fall outside of the traditional sweet spot for banks and other lenders, Danna said.

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Boulevard books \$70M to help beauty and wellness salons with their bookings

Beauty may be in the eye of the beholder, but when it comes to getting ahold of an appointment for your hair or another treatment...that's a different story: The bespoke nature of a lot of the work has meant that a large swathe of the professionals providing these services have stayed offline when it comes to interfacing with customers.

But that is changing, and today, [Boulevard](#) — one of the wave of software companies that's building a route to digitizing booking appointments, messaging clients, and taking payments for hair salons, nail salons, barbershops, face and skin care service providers, and others in the world of beauty and wellness services — is announcing that it has raised \$70 million in funding, a signal of changing demand and the traction this startup in particular is getting in the space.

IMAGE CREDITS: ROGER VIOLLET / GETTY IMAGES

The funding, a Series C, will be used to continue expanding Boulevard's product and engineering teams and to build out more tools targeting an ever-wider set of users in the bigger wellness and beauty sector (those product additions are typically big — it most recently added a whole new payments feature). This round is being led by Point72 Private Investments, with previous backers Toba Capital, Index Ventures, Bonfire Ventures, BoxGroup, and VMG Partners also participating.

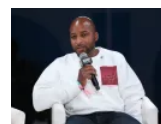
It brings the total raised by the company to around \$110 million (per [PitchBook](#) data) since Boulevard was founded in February 2016; and while the startup is not disclosing its valuation, CEO and co-founder Matt Danna said in an interview that the figure has tripled since last summer — particularly notable,

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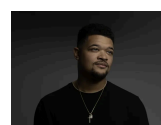
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given the current pressures in the tech sector and overall financial markets.

To be clear, Boulevard faces a lot of competition — other big names include Zenoti, which at the [end of 2020](#) was valued at over \$1 billion; Booksy, which [PitchBook](#) estimates was valued at just under \$540 million in November 2021 after it, too, [raised \\$70 million](#) earlier that year; and Fresha, which was [valued at over \\$640 million](#) at the end of 2021, among many others.

But at the same time, Los Angeles-based Boulevard got this funding infusion at a boosted valuation because it has been on a roll. Focusing on the U.S. to date, the company said that it saw an 188% growth in annual recurring revenue compared to a year ago, with more than 25,000 individuals in 2,000 salons and spas in the country now using its platform. It's also a massive market — and by Danna's estimates, still with a lot of untapped business — with Boulevard quoting figures that forecast personal care and beauty sales passing \$1.4 trillion, and the spa sector passing \$150 billion, both by 2025.

The gap in the market that Boulevard is building to fill is that one-person bands, independent salons, and bigger chains all grapple with the same problem. Personal care is exactly that — personal and individualized — and therefore it's been tricky for personal care specialists to use scheduling tools to organize it. Individual clients have differing requirements, treatments may take more or less time, and specialists are not robots whose time management can be predicted.

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Danna and his co-founder, CTO Sean Stavropoulos, previously worked together at Fullscreen as head of product and head of engineering, respectively. They were early to that idea: Danna describes it as “creator tools for YouTube before YouTube built them itself,” and he said they came up with the idea for Boulevard out of a joke between them. “I was making fun of [Sean’s] hair and saying he needed it cut, and he was telling me he couldn’t find time to get on the phone for an appointment,” he said. They realized there was a lot of friction in the process that didn’t need to be there: *Why* did they need to make a phone call in this day and age?

“We started obsessing about this,” Danna went on. They decided that this would be what they would tackle and build as a business.

Things then took an investigative, plainclothes turn. The pair posed as UCLA students doing research, Danna said, going from salon to salon asking questions about what worked and what did not with scheduling in their workplaces. They built a picture of why so much was still done offline. In short, it was about “yield optimization,” Danna said. Specialists and their salons wanted to be perfectly booked up, and salons weren’t actually completely offline, either. Roughly half used some software on premises or in the cloud, but none of it did the trick both for the salons or their customers.

IMAGE CREDITS: BOULEVARD UNDER A CC BY 2.0 LICENSE.

Their solution was to give users more control over how to build and personalize appointment lengths for clients, depending on specific treatments and specialists, and for each booking to in turn affect how the rest of the day’s schedule looked (not unlike Google Maps and the [constraint solver](#) used to help estimate travel time for vehicle routing in a particular set of traffic conditions, Danna explained). In time, the plan will be to also help individual consumers (clients) build their own profiles that can be applied to any bookings they

make with a particular salon, and maybe potentially elsewhere, too, marketplace style.

The rebound that Boulevard saw in the pandemic is another sign of the demand in the market, and perhaps a signal that its customers and the industry in general are more recession-proof than some might have assumed. Danna said that Boulevard's business took an inevitable pause in the second quarter of 2020 as COVID-19 took hold, but "it was bouncing back within a quarter of that," he said. Albeit that is with a different-shaped set of workers.

"Across all of the businesses we work with, they are doing 15% more revenues than pre-pandemic, although they are down 20% staff," he said. "It was a big reshuffle."

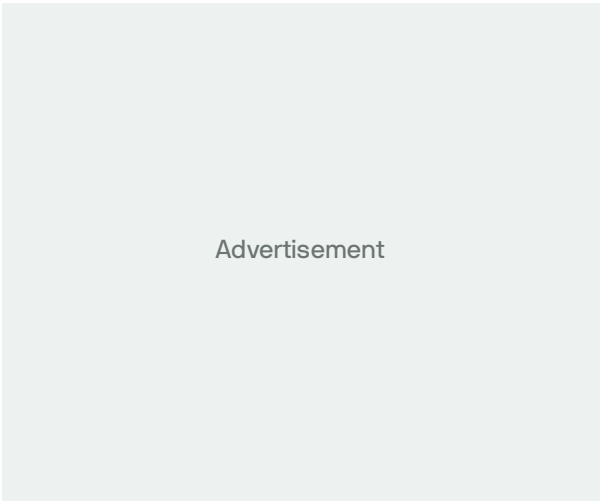
It will be interesting to see how and if that continues to play out as Boulevard eyes up international expansion. But for now, it's a startup its investors believe is on solid footing in its home market.

"As the self-care industry continues to grow, so too will the role technology plays in creating the seamless experiences that keep clients coming back," said Eddie Kang, a partner at Point72 Private investments, in a statement. "Not only has Boulevard designed an elegant and visionary platform that fills a pressing need in a fast-growing industry, but they've also built a thoughtful, customer-centric culture validated through world-class retention. We're excited to support the Boulevard team as they continue to grow." Kang is joining the board with this round.

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